Langers is like, ‘He always does this! I can’t see the damn stumps! Where the hell must I bowl?’

Hayden is a big guy – just unbelievably big and strong – and he’s an amazing hitter of the ball. He has all the power in the world, and he doesn’t take a step backwards for any bowler. If he wants to stand a metre outside his crease, he’ll do it. Shoaib Akhtar can be steaming in, bowling at 160 km/h, and Hayden will walk down the wicket and smack the ball over his head. And he even does that in Test cricket. I mean, the bowlers just shit themselves. Ours certainly did in the 2007 World Cup semi-final against the Aussies. When Hayden was standing there, smacking the ball to all corners, you could see the panic flicker across the bowlers’ faces.

And he enforced this fear even though we had a game plan against him. Obviously, in preparation for the match, we went through the Aussie players’ strong and weak points. When we had played them in the first group game, they scored 377, and Hayden took Shaun Pollock apart. In the end, Polly had ‘the claw’, where he was just kakking himself and couldn’t release the ball properly. Hayden was smacking him all over the show and Polly had no answer that day. I don’t think Polly was the same bowler again in that tournament.

Even in Australia, where the wickets are a lot quicker and bouncier, Hayden just stands, like, a metre outside his crease and pumps it into the stands. I’ve chatted to Matt a few times down the years, and he’s told me about a particular shot he practises in the nets. He calls it the ‘bowler crusher’.

It’s a fairly straightforward shot with a fairly obvious purpose where Matt isn’t going for a six, but is simply smashing the ball back at the bowler as hard, and preferably as low, as he can. It’s pure intimidation, which is part and parcel of the Aussie game plan, whether batting or fielding.

As we all know, sledging is part of the Aussie strategy, and Hayden always had a bit to say when his mates, Justin Langer and Steve Waugh, were with him. He certainly wasn’t shy of having a word. Not that I could specifically remember what he had to say, as all that stuff was always just noise to me. Even though it was always there, going on in the background, I never paid it much attention. And most of it didn’t come from Shane Warne, either, but from Justin Langer and Steve Waugh – not when Waugh was in the covers, but when he was in the slips with Warne.